

WHEN FILMMAKER ADITYA DHAR AND HIS BROTHER LOKESH of B-62 studios walked in late in 2024 to tell Jyoti Deshpande, president, Jio Studios (Media & Content Business RIL), the story of an Indian spy embedded in the gangs of Karachi, little did they know they were about to rewrite box-office history. Aditya, after debuting with blockbuster *Uri: The Surgical Strike* (2019), and producing three films, was itching to get into the director's chair, and he had seen an ambitious big-budget project get stuck already. The task of narration at the pitch meeting was assigned to Ojas Gautam, brother of Aditya's wife, the actress Yami Gautam.

Deshpande recalls the day vividly. "The script was very long," she says, in an interview after Part 1 of the film became a roaring success. It was high on action set-pieces, many of them violent, and almost all unfolding in Pakistan. The resulting A (adult) certification meant the film wouldn't be a family outing. "All the standard, formulaic commercial filters that would apply in greenlighting a project would summarily fail," thought Deshpande. "And it was an expensive film." But she liked its character- rather than plot-driven format, and its take on patriotism. "It wasn't in your face and was still more moving than most patriotic films," she says.

And so, *Dhurandhar* was born. When the first schedule wrapped, the film had already exceeded its budget, but the makers saw the rough footage and knew